

HM 481: READING PLATO: BETWEEN PHILOSOPHY AND LITERATURE

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COURSE ABSTRACT

Plato is a charming writer of philosophy in the form of dialogues. He wrote more than thirty dialogues, ranging from short to long ones, which deal with almost all the important problems and topics of philosophy. More importantly, all his dialogues contain, in varying degrees, literary embellishments in the form of striking character portrayals, powerful metaphors and analogies, drama and vivid exchanges and so on. In this course, we'll study a few Platonic dialogues with the aim of understanding Plato's controversial views on politics and democracy.

We will study the following dialogues:

1. *Apology*
2. *Gorgias*
3. *Laches*
4. *The Republic*

Secondary Readings:

Monoson, Sarah. *Plato's Democratic Entanglements*.

Allen, Danielle, S., *Why Plato Wrote*, Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010

Kraut, Richard. *Cambridge Companion to Plato*. Cambridge: Cambridge University press.

Wolin, Sheldon. *Politics and Vision*

Euben, Peter. *The Tragedy of Political Theory*

Mode of Teaching: The course will be organized around several issues which arise from each dialogue we study. The lectures will help you in critically approaching the assigned readings. Discussions are aimed at targeting the specific aspects of the readings, such as ideas, difficult passages and arguments. Freewheeling discussions are not encouraged at all. There will be periodic quizzes. Independent study and initiative will be highly encouraged and the required guidance would be provided.

Writing: You will be asked to write three short papers, varying between 1000 to 3000 words each, over the course of the semester. The word/page limit will be specified at the time of assigning the task.

EVALUATION

The first paper will count for 30%, second paper for 40% and the final paper for 30%.

PLAGIARISM AND ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Submitting someone else's work as your own, or using others' words and phrases without proper citation, is a violation of norms of academic integrity, and may result in penalties up to and including a failing grade in the course. Genuine effort and commitment will have direct bearing on the evaluation.